

PROLOGUE

Those eyes.



Those eyes carried both worry and wonder at the same time. And why would they not? Anyone who found themselves standing in a place like this would wear the very same expression.

Yet there was something else hidden within those beautiful blue eyes. Something deeper than confusion. A feeling so small that it could barely be noticed, and yet powerful enough to set an entire story into motion.

The young man stood silently.

His tall frame seemed almost lost amidst the endless fog. Long wavy hair fell over his forehead, dark as midnight at first glance, yet touched by a faint golden glow whenever the pale light found it. Beneath those strands rested a pair of striking blue eyes, clear and beautiful like a calm sky after rain.

And perhaps that was the strangest thing of all. Because beauty like his did not belong in a place like this. Or perhaps beauty belonged here more than anywhere else.

Nothing about this place made sense.

A vast forest stretched in every direction. Ancient trees rose so high that their crowns disappeared into the mist. It was impossible to tell whether the forest stood upon the earth or floated among the heavens themselves.

Yet in the middle of that endless wilderness rested a pond.

A small pond.

Peaceful.

Silent.

Golden fish drifted through its crystal waters, their scales shining like fragments of sunlight. Watching them brought a strange calm to his heart. For a moment, he forgot everything.

Then he noticed something. The fish were moving. Yet the water was not. Not a single ripple touched the surface. The pond was far too shallow for such movement to go unnoticed, and yet the water remained perfectly still, as if time itself had forgotten to flow.

A faint unease crept into his chest.

Then suddenly,

Splash.

The sound echoed across the forest. Ripples spread across the pond. The golden fish scattered in panic. His gaze followed the disturbance. On the opposite bank stood a towering figure.

An old man.

His long beard flowed down his chest. Thick matted hair was tied into a great bun above his head. A wooden staff rested firmly in his hand. Around his waist was wrapped a crimson cloth, while another light red garment draped across his shoulder and fell behind him like a faded banner.

The sight was both unfamiliar and strangely comforting.

The young man swallowed. "Who are you?" he asked softly. "Where am I?"

A gentle wind passed through the forest.
The fog shifted. And when he looked again, the figure was gone.
His heart skipped. Then a voice echoed directly within his mind.

"It matters not who I am."

The voice was calm.

"Nor does it matter where you are."

The forest seemed to fall even quieter.

"What matters is this moment. Your arrival here today."

The young man listened silently.

"This may seem like a dream to you. Perhaps it is a dream. But that is of little importance. When you dream, the dream feels real. When you live your life, that too feels real. So tell me, Parth. Which one is reality?"

His breathing grew heavier.

The voice continued.

"Whatever feels real becomes your reality. But that which constantly changes can never be truly real."

"The dream changes. The world changes. The body changes. The mind changes."

"And what changes will eventually disappear."

A strange pain rose within him. Without understanding why, tears began to stream down his face.

He closed his eyes.

The droplets fell from his cheeks and landed upon the pond below. Tiny ripples spread across the water.

Joining his hands together, he lowered his head.

"O Great Sage... I do not understand."

The voice returned.

"You already understand more than you realize, Parth. You have learned detachment. Now all that remains is for the ripples within your mind to settle."

Slowly, he opened his eyes. His gaze fell upon the pond. The disturbance was fading. The ripples grew smaller. The water became calm once more.

Moments later, the voice spoke again.

"You understand now."

He remained silent. Then another voice emerged within him. Not from outside. From within.

"The fish are like the beautiful thoughts that bring peace to our minds."

His eyes remained fixed on the pond.

"The water is the mind itself. When the mind is calm, beautiful thoughts remain close. And when an outside disturbance enters..."

His gaze shifted toward the ripples.

"...the mind becomes restless. The beautiful thoughts scatter. Just as the fish scattered when the water was disturbed."

A deep peace settled over him.

Slowly, he knelt beside the pond. His palms joined together once more.

Then, with serene eyes, he asked,

"O Great Sage... If anxiety awaits me in the days ahead...Then reveal its source."

He lowered his head. The forest became silent.

Completely silent.

Then a presence appeared before him. The sage stood only a few steps away.

A gentle smile touched his lips.

"Now I know. It is you."

The young man remained bowed.

"It is you, Aryan."

His heart trembled. Yet his eyes remained closed.

The sage continued.

"Parth, the meaning of everything I have told you is simple. In this world, every person wears a different body, a different mind, a different personality. Just as people wear different clothes."
The sage looked toward the sky hidden behind the fog.
"But the one who wears those garments is the same."

"Consciousness."

"What lives within you lives within me. What lives within me lives within all beings. We are not separate. We merely appear separate."

The old sage pointed toward a distant tree.

"We are fruits of the same tree. And this entire universe is another fruit born from that very tree."

"That tree is the Supreme Father."

"The Almighty."

"From Him all life emerges. And to Him all life returns."

Tears flowed once more from Aryan's closed eyes. Not tears of sorrow. Not tears of joy. Something deeper. Something beyond words.
After a long silence, he finally asked,

"Has the time come?"

The sage nodded.

"Yes, Parth."

"That is why I have given you this wisdom directly. The path ahead will not be easy. There will be suffering. There will be separation. There will be moments when the darkness appears endless. But no darkness can survive forever before one who knows the truth."

Aryan slowly lifted his head.

"Has this knowledge reached her as well?"

The old sage smiled.

A smile filled with affection.

"Parth..."

"Though two bodies stand apart, consciousness knows no distance. The bond between true soulmates does not belong to one lifetime. It flows

through many. It speaks even when words cannot. It remembers even when memories fade."

A gentle breeze moved through the forest. The fog danced around them. Aryan lowered himself completely. Touching the sage's feet with both hands, he bowed his head to the ground with absolute reverence.

The sage raised his hand in blessing.

And in a voice that carried the warmth of a father and the authority of eternity, he said,

"May the Divine protect both of you until the hour for which you were born finally arrives."

The forest fell silent once more.

And somewhere beyond the mist...

destiny had already begun to move.

